

## Let sleeping slob lie

OK, it was only a matter of time, so we are not surprised. A group of 2,000 cellphone owners have formed an "Excuse and Alibi Club" in the US, where one member lies on behalf of another. The club is modelled after its German founder, known only by the name 'Numbrrrs'.

Here's how it works: Cellphone users download background noise of traffic jams, and then play them when they call their bosses, or spouses to say that they're late. While someone close to the club admitted the ethics surrounding that application is a bit dubious, the software's creators, a company named SounderCover insist that people are only having fun.

The software is compatible with certain Nokia phones, which mainly run on the cellular-phone networks in Europe. In India, where numbers of mobile phones are increasing by the day, mobile phone ethics are a serious problem. The scenario will get further aggravated with sophisticated technology. Will the user wait for stringent legislation, or will we be ethical while there's time?

Time Magazine, as mentioned in a story earlier, missed one more reason for failed marriages!

### snapshot

By **2009, 43** million handheld gamers will be generating revenues worth **2.7** billion dollars

Source: Jupiter Research

## Goodbye Wi-Fi, says Microsoft

Microsoft's affair with Wi-Fi has ended.

In what is considered to be a total U-turn on its wireless policy, Microsoft has decided to discontinue its entire line of Wi-Fi gear. Microsoft had a complete line of Wi-Fi products including base stations, laptop cards, and USB and PCI add-ons for desktop machines.

It had entered the Wi-Fi

market only last year and notched up an impressive No 2 position. But soon other wi-fi manufactures caught up and MS's delay in delivering for the "g class routers" resulted in its fallen market share.

Although Microsoft claims to have accomplished its goals of using wi-fi on security, ease-of-use and performance, the real reason may somewhere lie in "G Products".

## Godfather@spammers.com

Spammers of the world Unite—the Mafia is now after you. But the Mafia being the Mafia, it won't bump the spammers off (damn!); instead hire them to write viruses to enable them to send spam.

If Eugene Kaspersky, head of anti-virus research at Moscow-based Kaspersky Labs, is to be believed, the advent of forthcoming laws that make spamming illegal has increased criminal interest in spamming. "If you have a profitable, illegal business, sooner or later, you pay taxes to the Mafia," said Kaspersky.

Though there is little to support his theory, Kaspersky reckons that if organised crim-



inals take control of spamming, they may reduce in number. However, the odd attack may be lethal.

Kaspersky has word of consolation, though: "It is unlikely that criminals would take over anti-virus and anti-spam companies, as the family 'needs effective anti-virus and anti-spam too.'"

## Have a virus? Call Dr Bill

Microsoft India has announced a tool to help organisations automatically remove the Sasser worm (W32.Sasser.A, and its variants). The tool is available free of cost, and can be downloaded from [www.microsoft.com/india/security](http://www.microsoft.com/india/security).

Microsoft also informed

customers that they can protect themselves against these attacks by first ensuring that their firewall is in place, and then installing Microsoft Security Update MS04-011.

Customers can alternatively call Microsoft India's Free Virus-support Helpline at 1901-333334.



## Spam

### Married, lonely and now poor

The US Federal Trade Commission (FTC) has filed charges against a spammer in the US and his associate in the Netherlands who used spam to drum up business for an adult site called 'Married But Lonely'. The defendants are to pay \$112,500.

However, they could not be tried under new anti-spamming regulations since the spamming occurred before the legislation came into effect.

In its complaint, the FTC pointed out that the consumers were not expecting adult related content with such subject lines, and that work place rules could have been violated.

### Spam Warnings

A US court quashed a restraining order passed against SpamCop.net that prevented the anti-spam service from warning ISPs of spam originating from their networks. SpamCop, now owned by IronPort Systems, is a service that has worked actively with ISPs warning them misuse of their e-mail services.

An online marketing company called OptInRealBig.com filed a case saying that with SpamCop squealing away, OptInRealBig lost contracts with ISPs and customers. The courts initially passed a restraining order against SpamCop, and after reviewing SpamCop's reply to it, the order was dissolved.

### snapshot

**82 per cent** of all US e-mail is spam

Source: MessageLabs Inc

